his trust. He gives people who are close to him a long rope until something hits him. Then he is so hurt that he works to bring the betrayer to book, says Muthuraman.

The most glaring case would perhaps be that of Dilip Pendse, former MD of Tata Finance. Pendse was Ratan's blue-eyed boy. Ratan had a lot of faith in him, but the MD breached it. SEBI found that Pendse had diverted the funds deposited by investors in Tata Finance through two companies, causing losses to the depositors. Passing an order, it barred Pendse and three others from 'accessing the capital market for manipulations at the time of Tata Finance's rights issue in 2001'. The fraud cost the Tatas around Rs 500 crore.

The Tatas filed cases against Pendse 'who some old-time company insiders say could have had a career as glorious as current Tata Group chairman N. Chandrasekaran', said Irani. Finally, Pendse died by suicide. Though Tata Sons was technically not obligated to make good the money to the depositors, Ratan did not shrug off the moral responsibility.

Irani said Ratan ensured that Tata Sons paid back all the jittery depositors who were fearful of losing their money. 'That is how Ratan honours the family name,' he averred. And he did it in the absence of any legal obligation and not knowing 'how big the hole in Tata Finance's losses' would be.

Ratan is a man of many opposites. He has a many-hued personality that is both refreshingly different but at the same time, incredibly inscrutable. He is both complex and simple, trusting but unkind to a fault, yet empathetic.

It is easy to misjudge him. Some may be misled by his affable and self-effacing manners and see them as a sign of weakness; but it is anything but that. He may look easily subduable, subdued into capitulation, but he cannot be, as many have discovered to their surprise. As much he is genteel, he is unbending in his resolve to stop what he sees as a wrong. But he is a man of equableness and grace, sedulously avoiding disrespecting anyone. He is a man of great depth, saying the most uncommon things using common words.

The focus of his life has been the improvement of the society and making the lives of people better, using the immense resources he commanded as the head of the largest conglomerate in the country. In the pursuit of this